

INTERVIEWING EFFECTIVELY



The purpose of an interview is to express your knowledge and qualifications to an employer while assessing if an organization is the right place for you to accept a position. Interviews may vary in length and in format. Regardless of the interviewer's style, keep in mind that you want to present yourself and your accomplishments in the best possible light.

During the interview listen carefully to what the interviewer is saying so that you can follow up with appropriate responses and questions. **Do not assume there are single right answers to interview questions.** It is often more important how you answer the question than the exact content of your responses. **Your attitude during the interview is also extremely important. Go into an interview relaxed, but professional with a positive attitude.** Never be defensive, arrogant, or self-effacing. You need to convey a sense of confidence and determination. Nearly all questions will be “open-ended” requiring much more than a one-word response.

BEFORE THE INTERVIEW

- **Research the organization.**
- **Review your resume.**
- **Practice your “personal pitch.”** Often the first question asked by employers is “tell me about yourself” and your answer should be a 30-second to 2-minute pitch briefly describing your background, qualifications, and why you are interested in the job. You can think of your pitch much like a cover letter, but out loud, touching on the most relevant aspects of your background that qualify you for the position. You do not need to discuss your childhood or personal details of your life, but rather discuss some key experiences you’ve had, the skills gained from those experiences, and how they relate to the job for which you are interviewing.
- **Practice, practice, practice.** Schedule a mock interview or two with the SGC or use our online tool, Big Interview.

DURING THE INTERVIEW

- **Be specific.** Give details and examples. General responses don’t help you prove your case to the interviewer.
- **Never broach questions of salary, benefits, or holidays until you have been offered the job.**
- **Make a positive last impression.** Thank the interviewer, shake hands, and try to find out what the next step in the interview process will be. Let them know you are sincerely interested in the position.
- **Ask for a business card to send a follow-up thank-you note,** which you should do that night from a computer.

EXAMPLE TRADITIONAL INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

- Tell me about yourself.
- Why are you interested in this field/in this position?
- Why do you want to work for our company?
- What courses did you like best? Least?
- How has your graduate studies prepared you for your career?
- Describe your most rewarding experience.
- What do you consider your greatest strengths and weaknesses? (NOTE: for the weakness, do NOT try to spin it into a strength; rather, choose something that is genuinely a weak area for you, but demonstrate that you are working to overcome it; ensure it is not critical to performing the job)
- What would your last boss say is your most exceptional quality? Areas that need improvement?
- What two or three accomplishments have given you the most satisfaction and why?
- How would you describe the ideal job for you?



INTERVIEWING EFFECTIVELY

- What are your short-range and long-range goals? Or what do you see yourself doing five years from now?
- How do you work under pressure?
- Tell me of a time when you overcame an obstacle or achieved a goal at a scale that you think most of your peers would have said was impossible.
- What have you learned from your mistakes?
- What qualifications do you have that make you think that you will be successful?
- How are you specifically going to add to our culture and make other people here better?
- How would you determine or evaluate success?
- Why should I hire you?

BEHAVIORAL INTERVIEWS

In a behavioral interview, an employer is looking for a set of core competencies needed to be successful in the position. Some examples of these include teamwork, communication, problem solving, and leadership skills. The premise of these types of questions is that past behavior is an indicator of future performance. The key to answering these questions is first to assess what skill the employer is trying to learn about. Then select an example that best demonstrates that you have this skill. Examples may be drawn from a variety of experiences, including work, volunteer/community service, extracurricular activities, and academics.

Behavioral questions usually start with the phrase “Tell me about a time when...” or “Can you give an example of a situation where...” For example, “Tell me about a time when you worked with a team and you failed.”

To answer these types of questions, think critically about your experiences. One way to prepare is to think of two or three stories/examples you can use for each of these questions. They don't necessarily have to come from your resume, but they should be recent (ideally not from high school) and you should not use the same situation more than twice in an interview. Your answers will need to involve details and descriptions so the interviewer gets a clear picture of how you handled the situation and your thought process in choosing that example.

The STAR Framework

Situation, Task, Action, Result (STAR) is a method to help you hit key points and present your examples in a structured manner. Think about it as storytelling; you must clearly explain your experiences to illustrate your background, skills, and personal characteristics.

Example: Was there a problem that required resolution or an initiative that you were asked to lead?

Situation: Set the stage and briefly provide background. Choose relevant examples that will demonstrate the skills the employer is seeking. You can draw from internships, leadership roles, extracurricular activities, or academics. Avoid personal examples unless they are directly related to the position.

Task: What tasks were you assigned and what were you trying to accomplish? What was your role and how did you help to solve the problem or accomplish the goal? Focus on your individual role, especially if you were working in a team. Though teamwork is valued, the interviewer is assessing your individual contributions.

Action: What steps did you take to accomplish that task? What was your plan of action?

Results: What happened as a result? What were your outcomes? How did your efforts contribute to the organization? If possible, quantify your answers.



INTERVIEWING EFFECTIVELY



Some typical behavioral questions ask about times when you:

- had to solve a problem
- helped a team to accomplish a goal
- worked on a team and it did not go well
- had to know something about a topic and do research
- motivated a coworker or peer to work better
- did something for a team and did not take credit for the good of the team
- organized an event or project and it did not go according to the original plan
- had to listen carefully to complete a project
- sought advice or feedback from someone
- had to deal with time constraints
- showed a great deal of initiative
- made a sacrifice for the betterment of the group
- had to rearrange priorities to meet certain goals
- helped or mentored someone
- had to give someone bad news
- encountered an especially difficult project
- dealt with an ethical dilemma
- had competing demands to fulfill and how you accomplished the results
- had to work with a difficult coworker or supervisor

EXAMPLE QUESTIONS FOR CANDIDATES TO ASK ON INTERVIEWS

When preparing for an interview, it is important to think of questions you can ask the interviewer about the organization and the position. Generally, the interviewer will allot time at the end of the interview for you to ask questions, though you can also ask questions as they arise naturally in the course of the conversation. Make sure to use the company website as well as other job sites to conduct research. You want to accomplish three things by asking well thought out questions to an interviewer.

The following are some examples of questions that you can ask.

- I noticed on your website discussion of the XYZ initiative. I'm wondering how that may affect this department or this specific role?
- Does your company offer any formalized training or continuing education for its employees?
- I recently read an article stating that this industry is facing ABC. What have the reactions been by employees at your firm to this stance?
- I recently read an article in the Wall Street Journal which predicted some of the trends of this industry. What is your take on the future growth of the organization?
- Describe the work environment and organizational culture.
- What is the overall structure of the department where the position is located?
- What are your expectations for new hires?
- What will be the biggest challenge facing the person taking this position?
- What are you looking for in a colleague?
- How is an employee evaluated and promoted?
- What characteristics does a successful person have at your company?
- What are the opportunities for professional growth?
- What is the retention rate of people in the position for which I am interviewing?
- Why do you enjoy working for your firm?



INTERVIEWING EFFECTIVELY



PHONE AND ZOOM INTERVIEWS

There may be occasions when an employer will request that you interview by phone or via Skype. Phone interviews are generally considered “screening interviews” and serve as the first round for employers to determine if they would like to bring you into the office for a formal in-person interview. You should prepare for a phone interview the SAME way as an in-person interview, as similar questions may be asked, and you must ensure you do your research. The difference is that you can have notes in front of you to help remember important points. Here are some tips for phone interviews:

- Never pick up the phone from an unknown caller when you are looking for a job/internship. Sometimes an employer will call and conduct a phone screen on the spot catching you off-guard. Let it go to voicemail and call back when you are in a quiet place and ready for the conversation.
- Speak slowly and ensure your volume is appropriate; ask the employer if he/she can hear you clearly. Try to use a land-line phone if possible. If you use a cell phone, test the reception BEFORE the call with a friend.
- Remember that since they cannot see you, your voice alone will need to convey your energy and enthusiasm.
- Perfect your personal pitch; it may be your only chance to show the employer why they should bring you in for another round of interviews.



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